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San Mateo to implement Axon cameras: The city will add ALPR cameras in new contract with Axon Enterprises

By Cecilia Schutz Daily Journal staff
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Accept

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San Mateo decided to expand its contract with Axon Enterprise, a major supplier of law enforcement technology, to include additional automated license plate readers that may replace its current cameras, despite facing significant backlash from residents in attendance at the City Council meeting Oct. 5.

The city is signing on to an eight-year purchase agreement with the company, which includes a one-year free trial period and payments beginning in June 2028. During the trial, the San Mateo Police Department will deploy Axon ALPRs to the same locations as the current cameras supplied by Flock Safety, another prominent law enforcement vendor, and conduct a side-by-side comparison to determine which system is preferred. With enough sample data, SMPD expects to identify the most suitable provider in the next six to nine months.

The decision to test out new ALPR hardware comes after the civil grand jury report, issued Aug. 3, found deficiencies in the city's Flock system, and cautioned that unauthorized data access and insufficient oversight mechanisms for the cameras is still a concern. While it remains to be seen if the implementation of Axon ALPRs will phase out the city's use of Flock cameras, Police Chief Ed Barberini said that this opportunity with Axon is "unique" and would allow SMPD "to provide the city with all of the available products."

"We have taken a very responsible approach to ALPR data in the city," Barberini said. "We have to be conscious and aware of other issues Flock has had in the state and across the country."

Many neighboring cities have revisited or discontinued its use of Flock cameras following nationwide scrutiny over the company's data-sharing practices. Mountain View announced its decision to turn its ALPRs off after finding that hundreds of law enforcement agencies, including several federal entities, had accessed its license plate data without authorization, the Mountain View Voice reported.

A comprehensive audit from April 2023 to May 2026 revealed that various out-of-state and federal departments had access to Redwood City's data, leading the city to not renew its contract with Flock, and seek out other vendors through a request for proposals. Half Moon Bay also let its contract with Flock expire, noting a general lack of distrust with the product.

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In a unanimous motion, the City Council accepted its response to the civil grand jury report. Several community members and activists at the meeting called upon the city to cease its use of ALPR technology altogether, and strongly objected to

bringing in another vendor.

“Many cities have found ALPRs made mistakes, or their data wasn’t properly shared to their surprise, with devastating consequences,” said Emily Morris, a San Mateo resident and member of Safety Over Surveillance San Mateo County, a privacy advocacy group. “We cannot rush into a new ALPR vendor when the city has not established the safeguards necessary for the next surveillance system.”

Kimberly Woo, a San Mateo resident and member of SOS, remarked on the similarities between Axon and Flock, and said that switching vendors would make no difference.

“Data privacy concerns do not disappear because the name on the camera changes,” she said. “Axon is Flock’s evil twin and has received millions of dollars from ICE. We simply cannot trust Axon to keep our data secure”

Axon Enterprise supplies Immigration and Customs Enforcement with body-worn cameras and electroshock weapons such as Tasers, and has entered into a handful of million-dollar contracts with the federal agency since 2020. President Donald Trump also bought between $1 million and $5 million in Axon stock back in February, which was noted by community members during public comment as a reason not to continue contracting with the company.

“You are contributing to the horrible corruption that we’re seeing and the self enrichment and degradation of our democracy that is happening at the national level,” said Tim Mackenzie, San Mateo resident and member of SOS SMC, addressing the council.

San Mateo Mayor Adam Loraine weighed tabling the contract for at least another month to make time for additional community outreach, “knowing that the contract might not be the same, and knowing that we risk losing the exact terms,” he said.

Out-of-State Hunters
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Chief Barberini and Councilmember Rob Newsom advised against waiting any longer to accept the contract, as the longer they wait, the greater chance they may lose the initial free trial with Axon.

“The contract is open ended, so we have a full year to decide whether we are going to pursue it,” Newsom said. “It doesn’t preclude us from having a town hall six weeks from now, and it doesn’t preclude us from saying that the city changed its mind.”

Councilmember Danielle Cwirko-Godycki referred to the city’s current agreement with Axon, stating that the company has been supplying San Mateo with body cameras and ALPR for law enforcement vehicles over the last 10 years. She said the short-staffed police department, coupled with the growing city population, warrants the continued use of the technology.

“Are we not thinking about the big picture here?” Cwirko-Godycki said. “We need some type of mechanism to help supplement our officers with enforcement.”

Councilmembers Nicole Fernandez and Lisa Diaz Nash agreed to move forward with the contract, under the condition that the city schedules a town hall meeting by the beginning of the new year, to garner more community feedback on the use of ALPR cameras in the city.

The motion to accept the contract passed in a 4-1 vote — with Loraine opposed.

The purchase agreement for ALPR cameras provided by Axon will cost the city a little over $1.4 million, with a cumulative total of more than $8.4 million, including the current contract. If continued, the contract for the Axon ALPR cameras will expire in June 2034.

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MORE INFORMATION



Flock camera data has insufficient systemic oversight in San Mateo County, grand jury finds

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